The Snake and the Mirror

The big idea

Vaikom Muhammad Basheer's humorous story (translated from Malayalam) is narrated by a young **homeopath** who is full of **vanity** about his looks. A sudden encounter with a snake shows him how small and helpless he really is. It is a gentle satire on human pride, told with self-mocking humour.

Summary

1. The poor homeopath rents a small room with a tiled roof but no ceiling, where **rats** run about. He has no electricity and comes home at night with a lamp.
2. One hot night he hears a dull sound, thinks it is a rat, and sits in front of his **mirror** admiring his face. He decides to shave every day, grow a thin **moustache** and always keep a charming smile.
3. He even plans to marry a **fat lady doctor** who has plenty of money, so that she can support him.
4. Suddenly a **snake** drops from the rafters onto his shoulder and coils around his left arm, its hood near his face. He freezes "like a stone image" and prays silently to God.
5. The snake turns its attention to the **mirror** and seems to admire its own reflection. The narrator jokes that it was perhaps wondering whether to grow a moustache or use make-up too!
6. Seizing the chance, the doctor slips out of the room and runs out of the house. When people return with a snake-catcher, the snake is gone, and with it the narrator's dreams of vanity.

SOURCE OF HUMOUR

The humour comes from **irony and exaggeration**: a man dreaming of beauty and a rich wife suddenly becomes a trembling statue, and the snake becomes another vain creature admiring itself.

Characters

- **The homeopath**: poor, vain, imaginative, but honest enough to laugh at himself. Fear wipes out his pride.
- **The snake**: almost a comic character, as vain as the man.

Themes

- **Vanity and pride**: looks and money are unimportant before death.
- **Fear and presence of mind**: staying still saves him.
- **Humour in a crisis**.

THE SNAKE DID NOT BITE

The snake never harmed him; it only coiled round his arm and then went to the mirror.

LIKELY QUESTIONS

What were the "two thoughts" the doctor had while looking in the mirror? How did he escape? Why did he change his mind about the "fat lady doctor"? Bring out the humour. Value points: rats, no electricity, moustache, smile, snake on arm, statue, prayer, snake at mirror.

Quick recap

- Vain homeopath admires himself in the mirror and plans a rich marriage.
- Snake coils on his arm; he stays still and prays.

- Snake goes to the mirror; he escapes. Message: vanity is foolish.

Practice questions

1. Who is the author of "The Snake and the Mirror"?
   (a) R. K. Laxman (b) Mulk Raj Anand (c) Gieve Patel (d) Vaikom Muhammad Basheer
2. What was the narrator's profession?
   (a) Homeopathic doctor (b) Schoolteacher (c) Snake-catcher (d) Lawyer
3. What noise did the narrator first think he heard?
   (a) A thief (b) The wind (c) A rat (d) A cat
4. While looking in the mirror, the narrator decided to
   (a) leave his job (b) buy new clothes (c) become a writer (d) grow a thin moustache and keep smiling
5. How did the narrator react when the snake coiled around his arm?
   (a) He screamed for help (b) He hit it with a stick (c) He sat still like a stone image and prayed (d) He threw it to the floor
6. What saved the narrator?
   (a) A neighbour came in (b) The snake fell asleep (c) The lamp went out (d) The snake moved towards the mirror
7. What were the narrator's thoughts as he looked at himself in the mirror?
8. How does Basheer use humour to make fun of human vanity?

Answers: 1. d 2. a 3. c 4. d 5. c 6. d 7. see notes 8. see notes